

Even predicting the effects of known technologies is difficult. This was made embarrassingly clear when the MIT journal *Technology Review* published an article in 1983 called "Disagreeing with the Future," which examined a set of predictions made by "professional futurists" in 1972 about what life would be like in 1980–85. All of the twenty items forecast seemed like good prospects in 1972; they were made by sensible, well-trained people, and they predicated projects that were socially beneficial and that used technology for the most part already invented. It was predicted, for example, that no cars would be allowed in most downtown areas, and that business travel and mail would be *down* 25 percent as people relied on audiovisual communication. Most of the other forecasts were equally wrong.

Just as important were the forecasts the futurists *didn't* make. There were no forecasts about personal computers, microwave ovens, cellular phones, video recorders, or extended-wear contact lenses.

Admitting the occasional miscalculations, I think one *can* nevertheless identify economic, social, and technological trends that will be important for the next several years, and decide when those trends have waned. It is certainly easier to do than it is to forecast where the market itself is headed, and more sensible. The market may be strong or weak, and the stocks that I choose as beneficiaries of trends may for a while be strong or weak in consequence, but if I am right in my themes, I know that in time my stocks will do fine and I needn't worry as much about the market's ups and down.

Recognizing the fallibility of almost any forecast, including my